Case Study on Building Approval-Based Workflow Automation in a Zoho Creator Application

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Aim

To automate a multi-level purchase approval process in Zoho Creator so that requests move to the right approver, decisions are recorded, and requesters are informed automatically.

Objectives

- Understand how approval workflows operate on a form record.
- Design approval levels using business rules.
- Configure actions to run on approval or rejection.
- Evaluate the improvement over e-mail-based approvals.

Selected Application

Orion Engineering Works (illustrative). Employees request purchases such as tools or stationery by e-mail. Managers lose track of requests, some purchases are made without approval, and nobody can tell afterwards who approved what. The company wants a controlled and traceable process.

Concept

In Zoho Creator an **approval process** is a workflow attached to a form. When a record is submitted it is held in a pending state and sent to the approver. The approver can approve or reject it, and the application executes the actions configured for each outcome. Deluge scripts can also be attached to the approval or denial of a record, for example to insert a record in another form.

Process Rules

Request value (Rs.)	First approver	Second approver
Up to 5,000	Department head	None
5,001 to 50,000	Department head	Finance manager
Above 50,000	Department head	Finance manager, then Director
Requester is a department head	Finance manager	Director if above 50,000

Form Design: Purchase Request

Field	Type	Note
Request ID	Auto number	Unique reference
Requested By	Lookup (Employee)	Defaults to logged-in user
Item and Justification	Multi-line	Mandatory
Estimated Amount	Currency	Greater than zero
Approval Status	Dropdown	Pending / Approved / Rejected
Approver Comments	Multi-line	Filled by approver

Workflow Flow

Step	Event	Action
1	Employee submits request	Status set to Pending; e-mail to first approver
2	Value above limit	Route to second approver after first approval
3	Approver approves	Status = Approved; record inserted in Purchase Order form; e-mail to requester and purchase team
4	Approver rejects	Status = Rejected; comments mandatory; e-mail to requester
5	No action in 3 days	Scheduled reminder to the approver

A short Deluge action configured on the approval outcome might look like this:

```
// On approval
insert into Purchase_Order
[
    Request_ID = input.Request_ID
    Amount = input.Estimated_Amount
    Status = "To be ordered"
]
sendmail
[
    from: zoho.adminuserid
    to: input.Requested_By.Email
    subject: "Request approved"
    message: "Your request has been approved."
]
```

Comparison: E-mail Process vs Workflow

Criterion	E-mail approvals	Creator approval workflow
Tracking	Search inbox	Status visible in report
Audit trail	Scattered	Decision, person and time stored
Rule enforcement	Depends on people	Amount-based routing is automatic
Delays	Unnoticed	Reminders and pending report
Reporting	Manual	Approvals by department, average time

Test Scenarios

Scenario	Expected result
Request for Rs. 3,000	Only department head approves; PO created
Request for Rs. 60,000	Three-step approval; PO after final approval
Rejected by finance	Requester notified with comments; no PO created
Approver on leave	Reminder sent; alternate approver can be set

Results

- Rules moved out of people's memory and into the application.
- Every decision became traceable.
- Approval time fell because requests no longer waited in inboxes.

Conclusion

Approval workflow automation is one of the strongest uses of a low-code platform. With a form, a few routing rules and simple scripts, Zoho Creator gave Orion Engineering control, speed and a complete audit trail, which were difficult to achieve with e-mail.

Sources consulted: Zoho Creator Help documentation (forms, reports, pages, workflows, Deluge); Zoho Corporation press release on Creator AI features (April 2025) and its coverage in IT Brief; Zoho Creator Decode article on Zia-assisted Deluge (March 2026). The business scenario in this report is illustrative, and figures in it are assumed values used to demonstrate the method, not measured results.